

Adding working custom food recipes (*Youtube link coming later*)

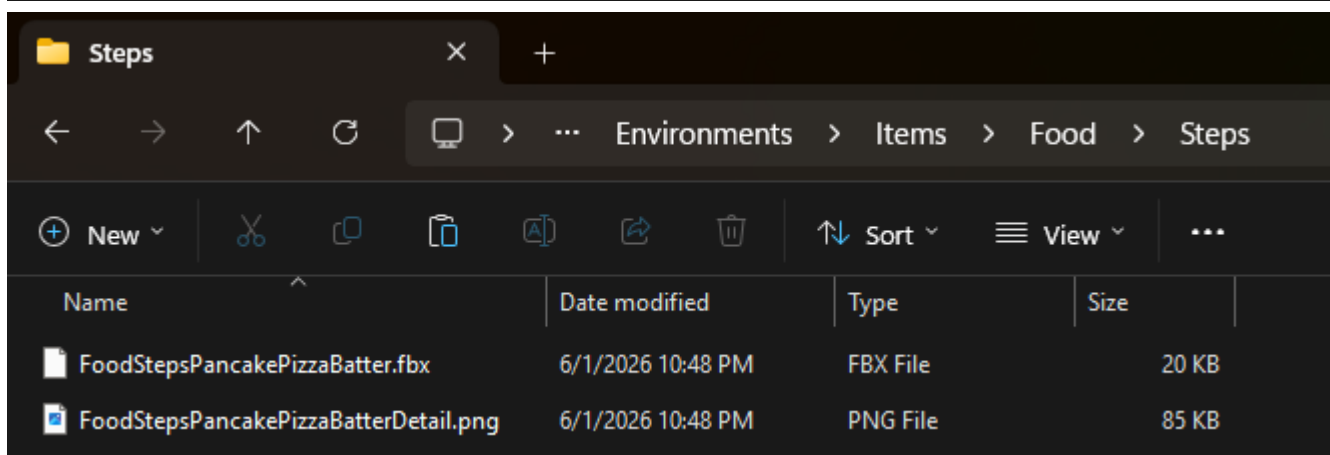
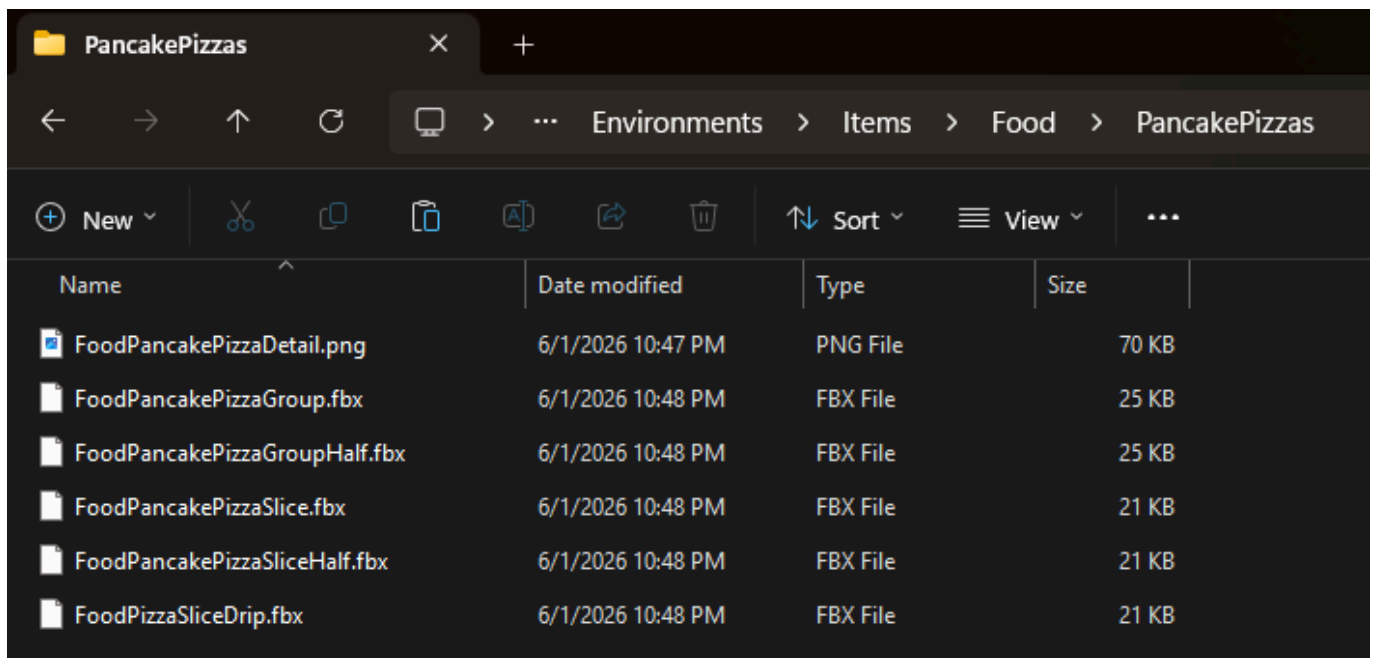
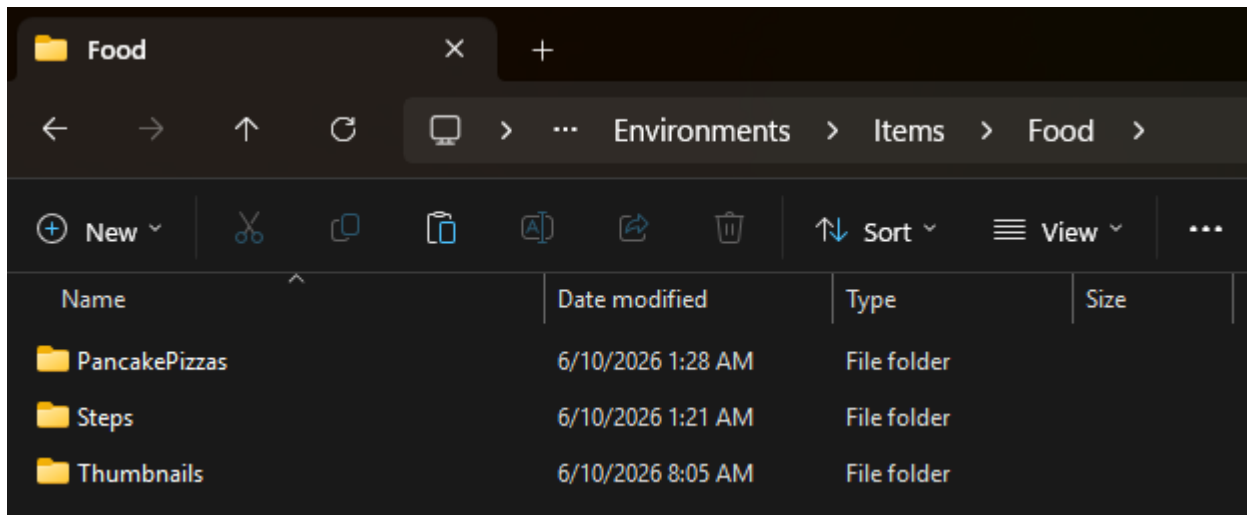
Intro

Paralives official Discord link: [\(LINK\)](#) *Note: This tutorial currently covers the methods to get a modded recipe recognised and usable within the game. Skin meshes currently incorrectly or do not get their detail map applied due to the Surface property missing from selection on new entries. There might be a way to get around this by applying your detail map to your FBX mesh directly. I have not tested this yet, but if it works I'll update the tutorial. I will also be creating more advanced food and other tutorials, so stay tuned.* 😊*

This guide assumes you understand the basics of the Paralives modding suite and 3D modelling. If you need help, I or others will have text and video guides on these topics, or if you prefer you can ask me here directly: <https://discord.com/channels/595045400805769238/1514044021411025039> **This tutorial may be adjusted for neatness and new information if needed.** *The screenshots may not be completely neat, but it should be clean enough for the sake of this written guide.*

Step 1: Asset setup

Folder setup



- Within your mod's files, create a new folder named **Environments** (You can quickly open the relevant Paralives folder by searching this in Windows directly: `%userprofile%\AppData\LocalLow\Paralives\Paralives\`). Within Environments, create another folder named **Items** and within Items **Food**.
- Inside the Food folder, create the folders **Steps**, **Thumbnails** and any other folders named after your food items. I named my demonstration item **PancakePizzas**, but the name is not necessary for functionality (*Naming the folders Steps and Thumbnails is not crucial for the game to read them, but*

doing this this is a good habit as it helps keep things organised and speeds up outside assistance if you need it.).

File types needed

You will need two file types: FBX and PNG.

- FBX: 1-6 for your food mesh.
- PNG: 1-6 for the detail map.
- (Optional) PNG: 1 for custom/styled menu thumbnail (it is necessary for now as without Surfaces the recipe icon does not generate in the menu at all). You need at minimum the mesh for your finished food item and the detail map to texture it. There are 2 mesh variations for group meals (**full, half**) and 4 with individual (**full, half, full-in-hand, half-in-hand**). You only require 1 detail map for both group and individual meals, but adding texture for each different mesh can be done if you want a specific look for each variation. You can also add your own recipe step meshes and maps (such as eggs and flour or batter), but vanilla comes with many detailed assets already made for this purpose. You can use vanilla animations or rig your own, but for this tutorial we'll use vanilla steps and animations. I'll be making an advanced guide later for adding animations and multi-step individual stages (such as for making a 3-tier cake), but those are more advanced concepts and once surfaces are working I'll make the tutorial for it.

Folder setup

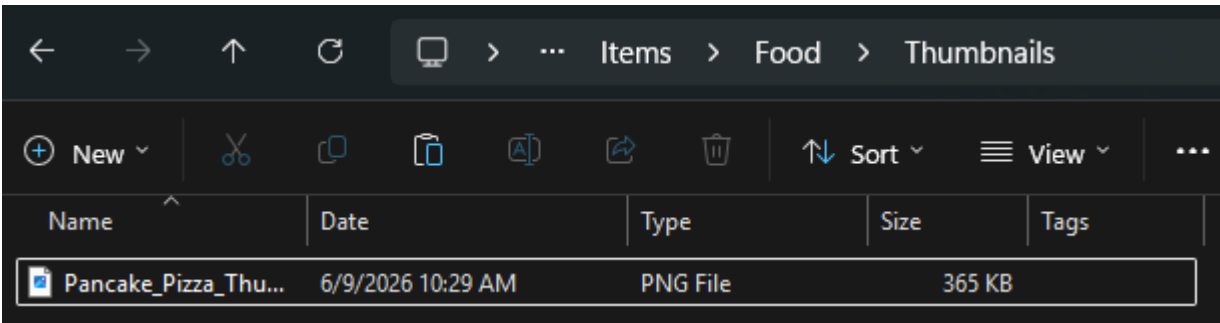
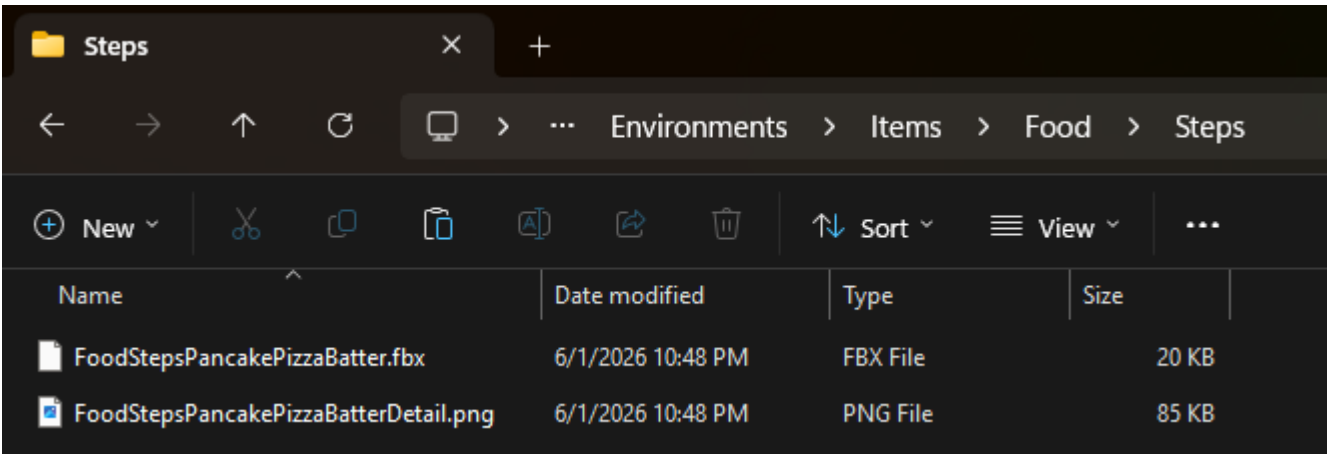
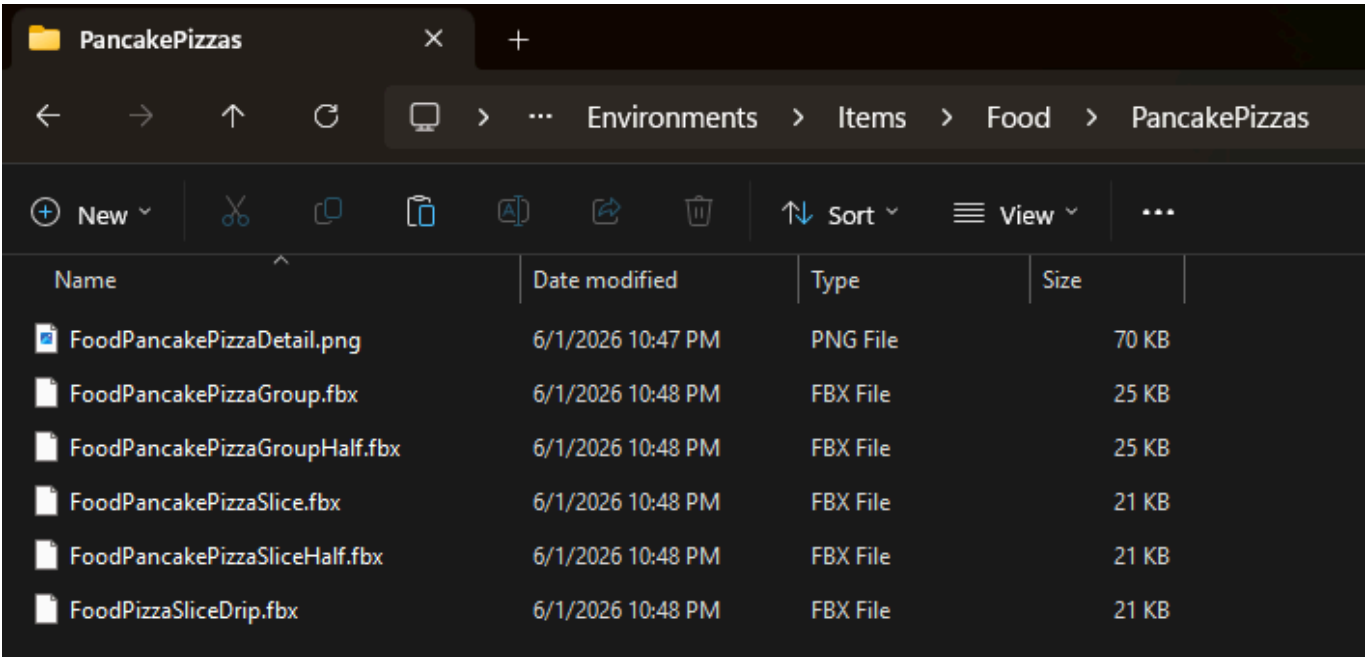
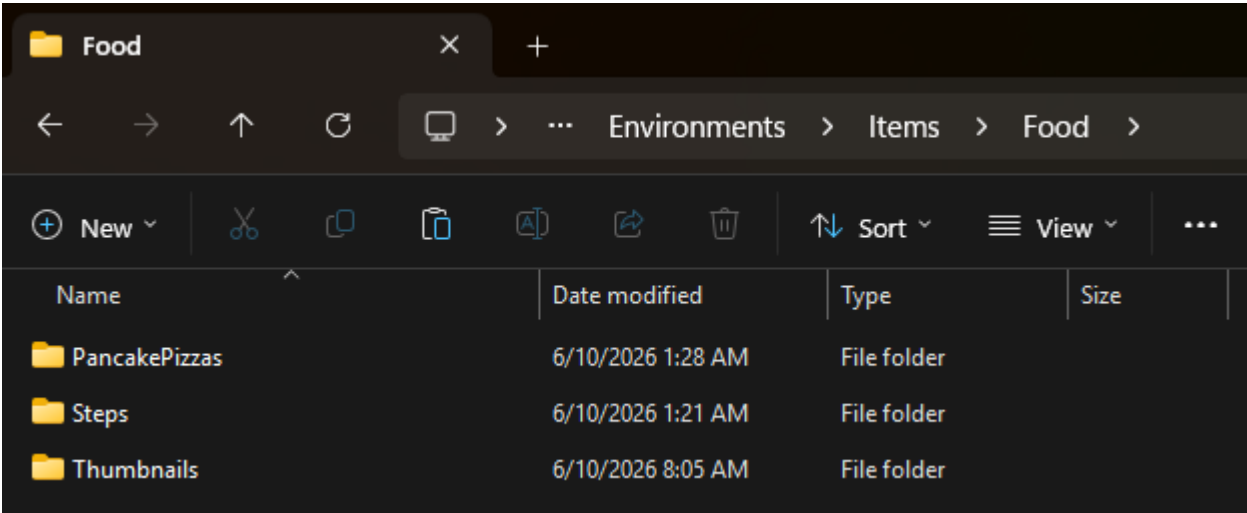
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`%userprofile%\AppData\LocalLow\Paralives\Paralives\`). Within Environments, create another folder named **Items** and within Items **Food**. Inside the Food folder, create the folders **Steps**, **Thumbnails** and any other folders named after your food items. I named my demonstration item **PancakePizzas**, but the name is not necessary for functionality (*Naming the folders Steps and Thumbnails is not crucial for the game to read them, but doing this this is a good habit as it helps keep things organised and speeds up outside assistance if you need it.).*

Folder explanation:

- **Environments** is the default vanilla directory/folder for Paralives, and holds all art assets, for example meshes, maps and prefabs.
- **Items** is the container for all interactable and visual objects in game, from computers to clutter to food.
- **Food** holds the mesh and detail maps for cooking assets and functional foods.
- **Food types** are individually named folders for categorising food assets. As said, these can be named anything, but should be descriptive of the meal for legibility (for example "Cakes").
- **Steps** is for the visual cooking process, such as taking cake batter from the fridge. These folders are merely cosmetic in reality, but it's good practice to keep them organised and tidy.

Recommended structure:



Step 2: Adding visuals and functionality

Categories

There are only two categories needed for full functionality:

Skins

Required for visual functionality of the entire meal system.

Skills

Necessary to see and cook recipes in the Cook menu. There are very few entries you will make here compared to Skins and is more straightforward.

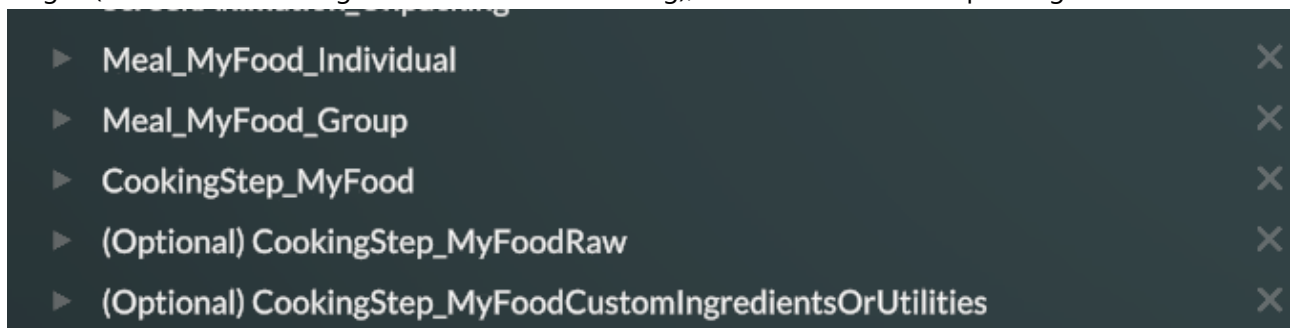
Initial functionality setup

Setting recipe menu visibility and skill level requirements

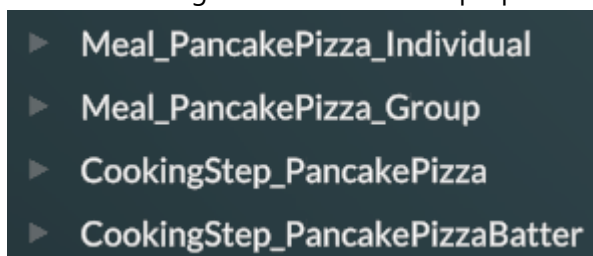


You only need to touch 2 categories: **Skins** and **Skills**.

1. Create your food entries. You need at minimum Meal_MyFood_Individual, CookingStep_MyFood, and if it's a group meal add Meal_MyFood_Group to these items. If your food can be cooked as both individual and group servings, another entry and name it CookingStep_MyFood_Individual. Creating additional Cooking Steps will allow you to add modded ingredients, cooking utilities or visual cooking stages (such as a cake rising when it's finished cooking), but this will not be explaining in this tutorial.



For the purpose of this tutorial we will use the required entries to create a group meal, as well as adding our modded ingredient. These are repurposed vanilla assets but are suitable for demonstration.



2. The Skills Cooking category only needs to be touched if you wish for your recipe to show up by default. If you do not want to do this and prefer for it to show up through gameplay, you can skip this step. Recipes not set in this way will show up through regular gameplay, either by leveling up the Cooking skill or discovering recipes through the computer etc. To automatically unlock this recipe for a Para when loading into a save, add it to one or more Initial Skins Packs. This will give it along with the other recipes in the selected pack to a new or existing Para. Adding it to more or all of the other packs will increase the chances of a Para having it by default.

▼ Cooking

Enabled

☐

GUID

3823409090312567399

Display Name

Cooking

Description

SkillDescription_Cooking

How To Improve

SkillHowToImprove_StudyingOnComputer

Parent Knowledge Skill

KnowledgeFood

Max Level

20

Restrictions

Restricted To Requirements

AdultModel

Skins

Has Skins

☐

▼ Initial Skins Packs

+

🔍

▼ Pack #1

×

GUID

6076515159959832541

Display Name

Pack #1

► Requirements

+

🔍

▼ Skin List

+

🔍

▼ Item 0

×

Value

Meal_HamburgerFrozen_Individual

► Item 1

×

▼ Item 2

×

Value

Meal_ToastEgg_Individual

▼ Item 3

×

Value

Meal_PizzaFrozenCheese_Group

▼ Item 4

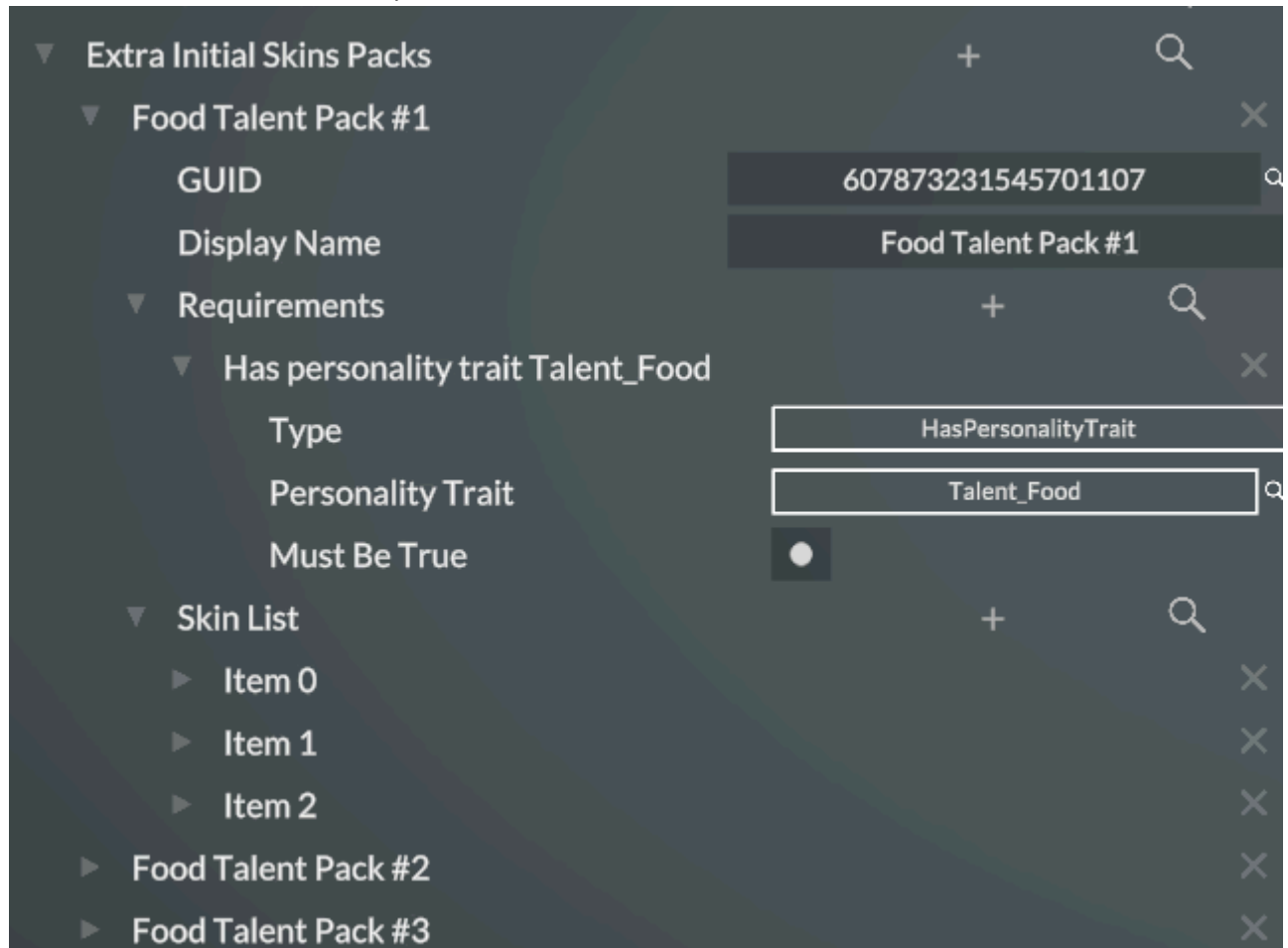
×

Value

Meal_PancakePizza_Group

You can also give it as an extra/bonus starting recipe for certain personality traits, such as having the

Food Talent. There's a lot more possibilities but this tutorial will not cover them.



- Go back to the Skins category. For each meal, You will add to the Parent Skins. In the screenshot the format is set out for you. You can set the recipe level to whatever you want, but make sure you have "_Single" and "_Group". If your recipe is a single serving meal, you will only need _Single. If a group meal, set to _Group. If your meal has a group serving, make sure you also add the individual version (Meal_PancakePizza_Individual in our example) **Make sure you click Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu,**

otherwise your meal won't show up in the Cook menu.



Setting meal visual properties and functionality

Tip: Using vanilla recipes as examples

A good tip is to use vanilla recipes for the cooking process that are similar to what you want. For example, since we are creating a pizza, we will use one of the vanilla pizzas as a basis for our meal: **Note: We do not look at Parent Skins as that was already set up in Step 3 of the previous section.** *Vanilla Pizza (Individual)*

▼ Meal_PizzaPineapple_Individual

GUID

Display Name

Skin Type

▼ Skin Properties

▶ Display Name

▶ Plate

▶ Meal

▶ MealHalfEaten

▶ MealInHand

▶ MealInHandHalfEaten

▶ EatingAnimation

▶ Parent Skins

Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu

2437834893248310407

Meal_PizzaPineapple_Individual

Recipes

+

+

×

×

×

×

×

×

×

×

Vanilla Piza (Individual) properties (1/2)

▼ Meal_PizzaPineapple_Individual

GUID

2437834893248310407

Display Name

Meal_PizzaPineapple_Individual

Skin Type

Recipes

▼ Skin Properties

+

▼ DisplayName

Tag

DisplayName

String Value

HawaiianPizza

Translation Reference

None

▼ Plate

Tag

Plate

Mesh

FoodPlateSmall.fbx

Detail Map

None

Decal Map

None

▼ Surfaces

► PorcelainBasic

▼ Meal

Tag

Meal

Mesh

FoodPizzaSlice.fbx

Detail Map

FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png

Decal Map

None

▼ Surfaces

► GenericFoodSurface

Vanilla Piza (Individual) properties (2/2)

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The image shows a skin editor interface with a dark background. On the left, a tree view lists skin properties. On the right, each property is assigned a value in a text box. Some text boxes have a magnifying glass icon, and some have a gear icon. At the bottom, there is a checkbox for 'Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu'.

Property	Value	Search Icon	Settings Icon
Skin Properties			
DisplayName			
Plate			
Meal			
MealHalfEaten			
Tag	MealHalfEaten		
Mesh	FoodPizzaSliceHalf.fbx		
Detail Map	FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png		
Decal Map	None		
Surfaces			
GenericFoodSurface			
MealInHand			
Tag	MealInHand		
Mesh	FoodPizzaSliceDrip.fbx		
Detail Map	FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png		
Decal Map	None		
Surfaces			
GenericFoodSurface			
MealInHandHalfEaten			
Tag	MealInHandHalfEaten		
Mesh	FoodPizzaSliceHalf.fbx		
Detail Map	FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png		
Decal Map	None		
Surfaces			
GenericFoodSurface			
EatingAnimation			
Tag	EatingAnimation		
Animation Tag	EatingSlice		
Parent Skins			
Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu			

Vanilla Piza (Group)

▼ Meal_PizzaPineapple_Group		
GUID		7553530063857596786
Display Name		Meal_PizzaPineapple_Group
Skin Type		Recipes
▼ Skin Properties	+	🔍
▶ Plate		×
▶ Meal		×
▶ MealHalfEaten		×
▶ SinglePortion		×
▶ CookingSteps		×
▶ Parent Skins	+	🔍
Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu	☒	
▼ Visibility Requirements	+	🔍

Vanilla Piza (Group) properties (1/2)

▼ Meal_PizzaPineapple_Group

GUID

7553530063857596786

Display Name

Meal_PizzaPineapple_Group

Skin Type

Recipes

▼ Skin Properties

+

Q

▼ Plate

×

Tag

Plate

Mesh

FoodStepsPizzaPlate.fbx

⚙

Detail Map

None

Decal Map

None

▼ Surfaces

Q

► FoodPlateMetalPizza

▼ Meal

×

Tag

Meal

Mesh

FoodPizzaGroup.fbx

⚙

Detail Map

FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png

⚙

Decal Map

None

▼ Surfaces

Q

► GenericFoodSurface

▼ MealHalfEaten

×

Tag

MealHalfEaten

Mesh

FoodPizzaGroupHalf.fbx

⚙

Detail Map

FoodPizzaPineappleDetail.png

⚙

Decal Map

None

▼ Surfaces

Q

► GenericFoodSurface

Vanilla Piza (Group) properties (2/3)

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▼ CookingSteps

Tag

▼ Skinned Steps

▼ CookingStep

Tag

Catalogue Item

Action Unit

▼ Skin References

▼ Item 0

Value

▼ CookingStep

Tag

Catalogue Item

Action Unit

▼ Skin References

▼ Item 0

Value

▼ CookingStep

Tag

Catalogue Item

Action Unit

▼ Skin References

▼ Item 0

Value

► CookingStep

► CookingStep

CookingSteps

+

CookingStep

FoodStepsFridgeBoardAnim

CookingStep_FridgeTakeIngredients

+

CookingStep_FlourButterEggs

CookingStep

FoodStepsMixingBowlAnim

CookingStep_CounterMixFood

+

CookingStep_Batter

CookingStep

FoodStepsFlourCounter

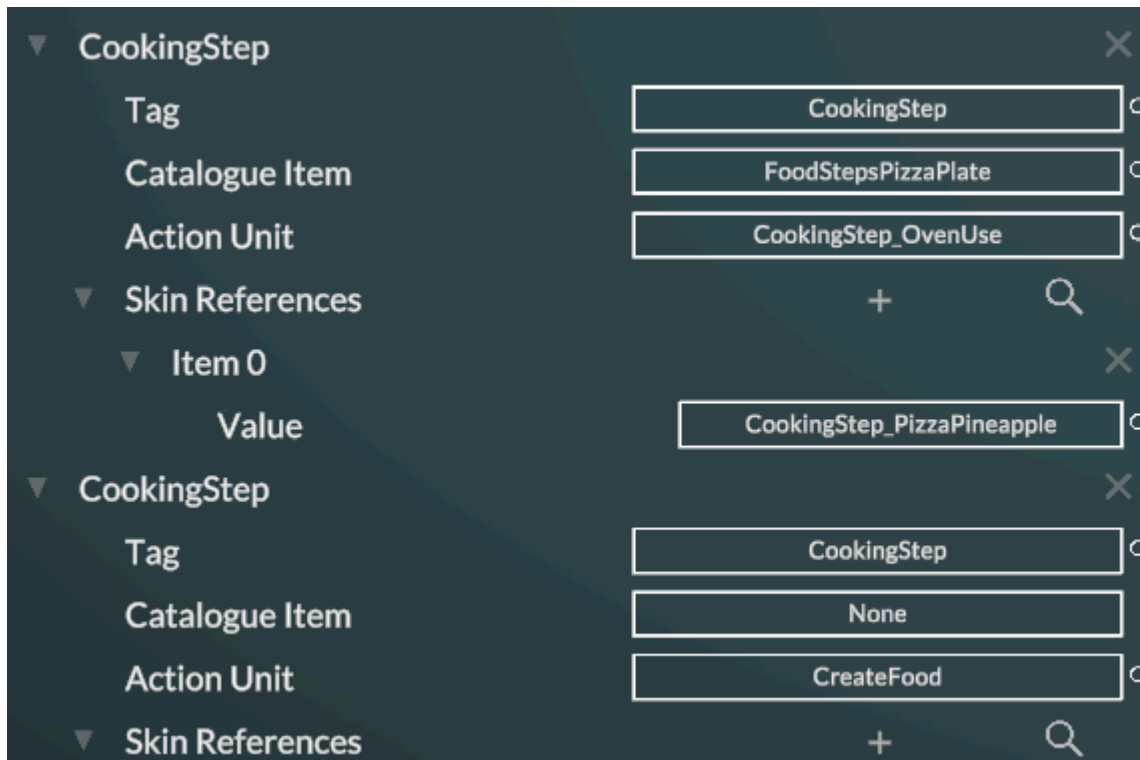
CookingStep_CounterRollingPin

+

CookingStep_Dough

Vanilla

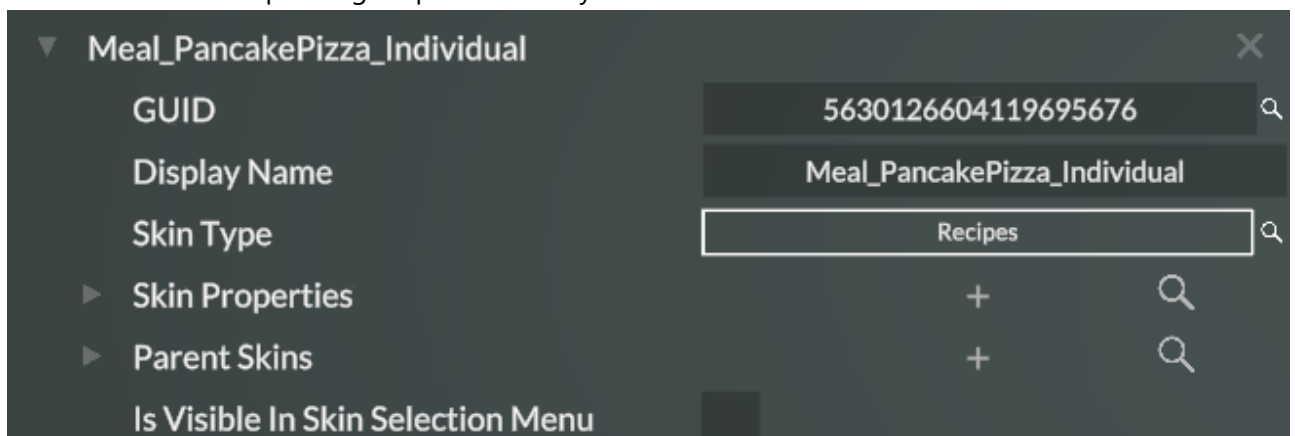
Piza (Group) properties (3/3)



Setting your food as a recipe

There are only two things you have to do here.

1. Set **Skin Type** to **Recipes**
2. Click and set **Is Visible in Skin Selection Menu** to enable it for cooking. Do this for Group, Individual or both depending on portion sizes your meal should be available in. *Individual*



Group

▼ Meal_PancakePizza_Group		
GUID	7135544908022603636	
Display Name	Meal_PancakePizza_Group	
Skin Type	Recipes	
▶ Skin Properties	+	
▶ Parent Skins	+	
Is Visible In Skin Selection Menu	☒	
▼ Visibility Requirements	+	

Explanation of important Skin Properties

Surfaces property will be empty due to the bug, so ignore that in your modded food for now. Decal Map is not relevant and will be ignored, as this is for dirty surfaces, broken objects etc. **This covers the basic outline of Skin Properties. I may or may not add a breakdown of all options found in each property at a later stage.**

Individual

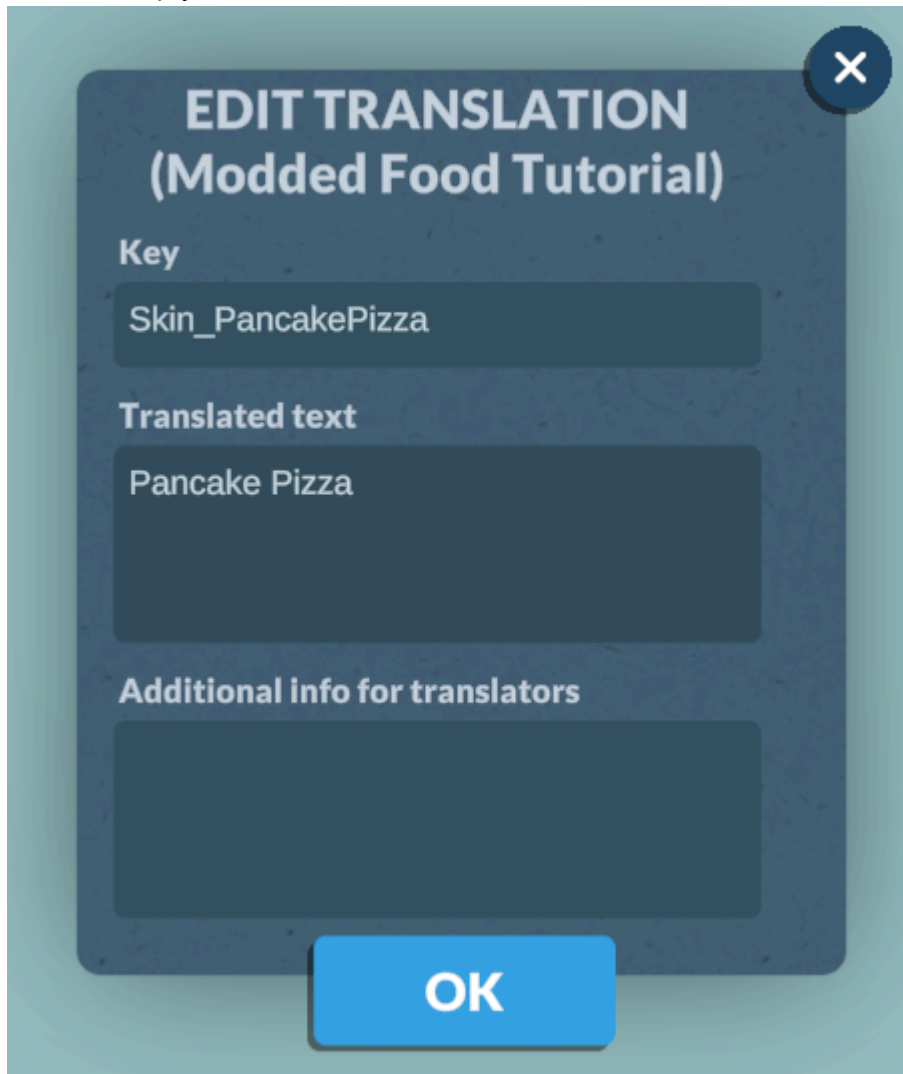
1. DisplayName: The name of your recipe will show up with the String Value of the DisplayName property. It is good practice to set the exact name you want to show up in the menu, and it also avoids potential issues with the name appearing in game. To do this click the symbol next to the String Value field: *This should only be set for the individual serving. Do not set for the group option.*

▼ DisplayName		
Tag	DisplayName	
String Value	PancakePizza	
Translation Reference	None	

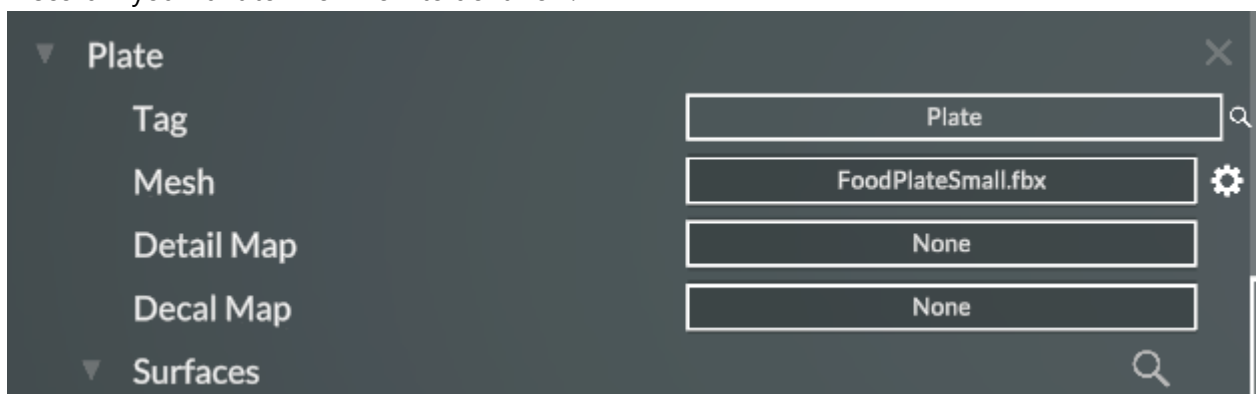
Edit the translation associated to this key.

A new window will pop-up in game. The only thing you need to edit here is the "Translated text" box. It

will start empty. This should be the name of the actual meal.

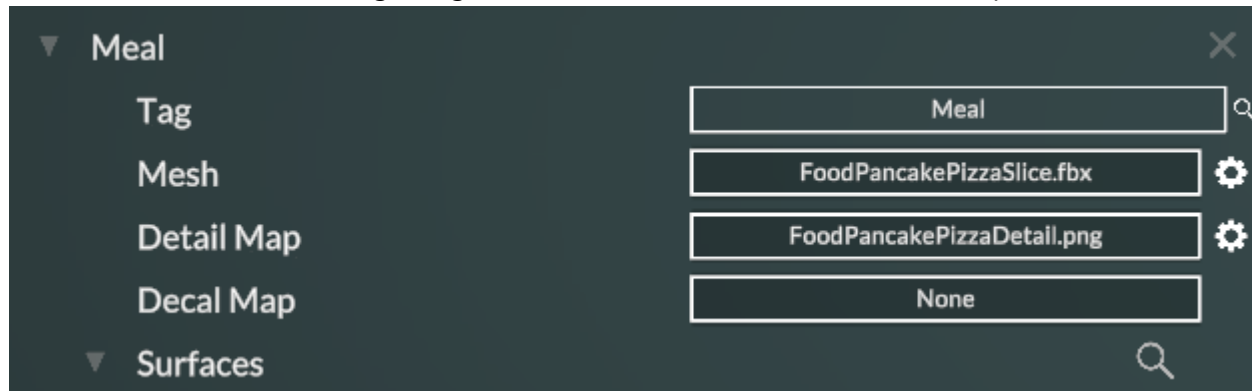


2. Plate: This is the type of plate your food will appear on after cooking. You can look at a vanilla meal if you want to see what plate works best for you. You can also add your own plate meshes, but that requires further setup that will not be covered in this tutorial yet, but you can send me a message on Discord if you want to know how to do it now.



3. Meal: The actual appearance of the cooked meal. Mesh is the FBX file of the food you will use. If the actual meal is a group serving, use the single portion variation if you have. Detail Map is the PNG of the

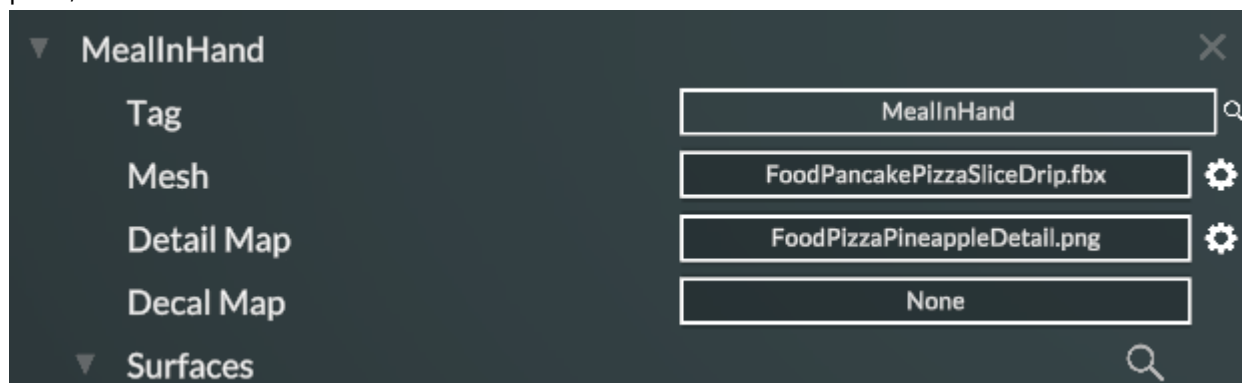
texture as discussed at the beginning. Can be used for both Individual and Group.



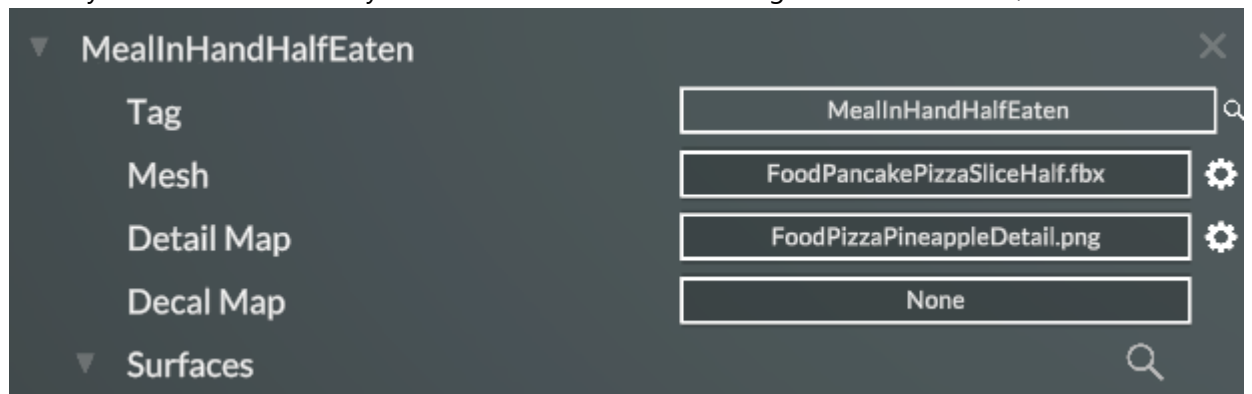
4. MealHalfEaten: The change in appearance when half of the serving has been eaten.



5. MealInHand: *(Ensure this is only set for individual, not group meal servings)* How the food appears on the plate, as well as in the hand if the animation is set as such.



6. MealInHandAndHalfEaten: Same as MealHalfEaten, but instead the appearance of the food while it is actively eaten. You can usually have this set to the exact settings as MealHalfEaten, such as for a cake.



7. EatingAnimation: The animation and objects used when eating the meal. For example, setting it to EatingSlice will have the Para pick it up off the plate, while EatPlateFork will use a fork when eating from

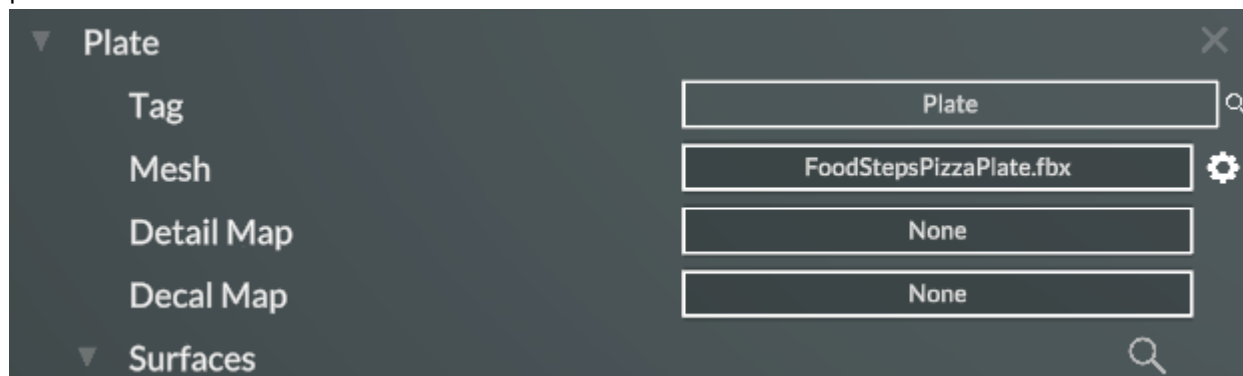
the plate.



8. **CookingSteps**: Can be set in either Individual or Group meal Skins. If the meal has an option to cook both a group serving and a single serving, you can set it here if the cooking process is the exact same for both. If you do this, you do not need to set it in the Group (setting it in Group will not cause any issues, but it will take unnecessary extra time to setup your food if the process is the same). *Covered in Group explanation below, but this must also be set if the meal has a single serving option.*
9. **Thumbnail**: Set this for the serving option or options that will be available to cook. *Example shown in Group below, as the Pancake Pizza is a group-only recipe.*

Group

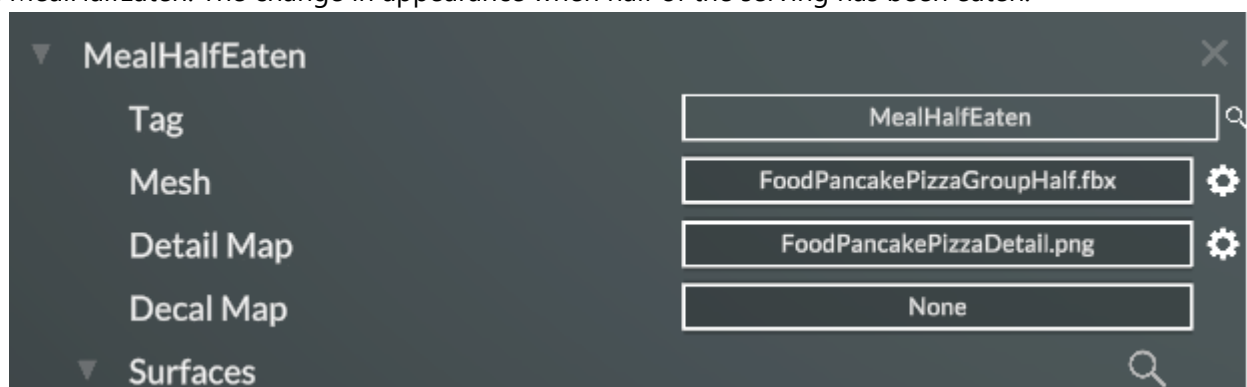
1. **Plate**: This is the type of plate your food will appear on after cooking. Look at a similar vanilla **Group** portion to see what works.



2. **Meal**: The actual appearance of the cooked meal. This is the group serving version. Detail map can be used for both Individual and Group.



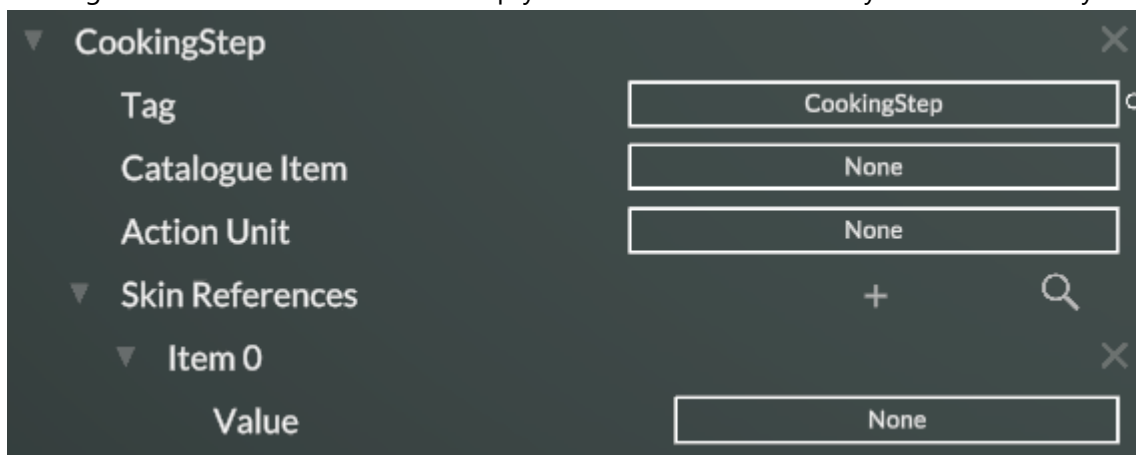
3. **MealHalfEaten**: The change in appearance when half of the serving has been eaten.



4. CookingSteps & Skinned Steps: The actual cooking process, from getting ingredients, to preparation and the final cooked meal. Individual CookingStep entries will be added to Skinned Steps. *(The actual amount of Skinned Steps you use will probably differ, as this example is for my Pancake Pizza)*



5. CookingStep: The individual stages of the recipe's progress. Created by adding a new entry to Skinned Steps and setting Tag to CookingStep.
- Catalogue Item: The visual stage of the recipe. filter your search by **foodsteps** to find the exact items used in recipes. Most will be animations (they will have "Anim" at the end) but some are not directly animations as they are static (Such as FoodStepsFlourCounter). I will explain how this works in Action Unit.
 - Action Unit: This is how the game understands what to do at this recipe stage.
 - Skin References: The visual item and/or ingredient that will be used at this stage, which is set in the Value field after adding an entry (search directly for **foodsteps** to quickly find related objects). *In most cases you will only add one entry, but you can also add more if your ingredients go through a visual change once this CookingStep is done (such as a having a cake rise fully after it is completed). I will explain in a future edit of this tutorial.* **IMPORTANT:** The Skin Reference *before* the final CookingStep must **always be your custom CookingStep_MyFood**. This tells the game that you meal is fully cooked and must be converted into the completed meal once this stage completes. Your final CookingStep entry in Skinned Steps must only have Action Unit, and this must be set to **CreateFood**. Leave Catalogue Item and Skin References empty or None. It will look exactly like this for every meal/recipe:



(CookingStep_MyFood will be explained after the Pancake Pizza screenshots below).

Pancake Pizza Cooking Steps:

▼ CookingSteps

Tag

CookingSteps

▼ Skinned Steps

▶ CookingStep

+

▶ CookingStep

▶ CookingStep

▶ CookingStep

▶ CookingStep

Step 1

▼ CookingStep

Tag

CookingStep

Catalogue Item

FoodStepsFridgeBoardAnim

Action Unit

CookingStep_FridgeTakeIngredients

▼ Skin References

▶ Item 0

Value

CookingStep_FlourButterEggs

Step 2

▼ CookingStep

Tag

CookingStep

Catalogue Item

FoodStepsMixingBowlAnim

Action Unit

CookingStep_CounterMixFood

▼ Skin References

▶ Item 0

Value

CookingStep_Batter

Step 3

▼ CookingStep

Tag

CookingStep

Catalogue Item

FoodStepsFlourCounter

Action Unit

CookingStep_CounterRollingPin

▼ Skin References

▶ Item 0

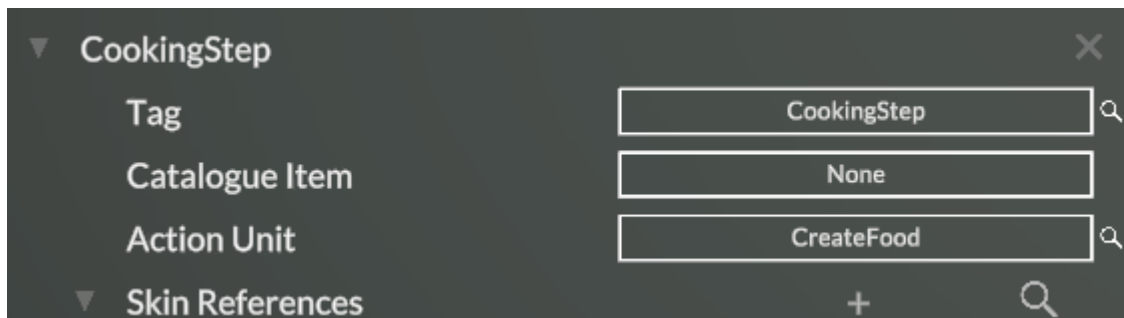
Value

CookingStep_Dough

Step 4



Step 5



9. Thumbnail: Set this for the serving option/options that will be available to cook. *This may not show up in previous screenshots as I forgot to add it until now xD*

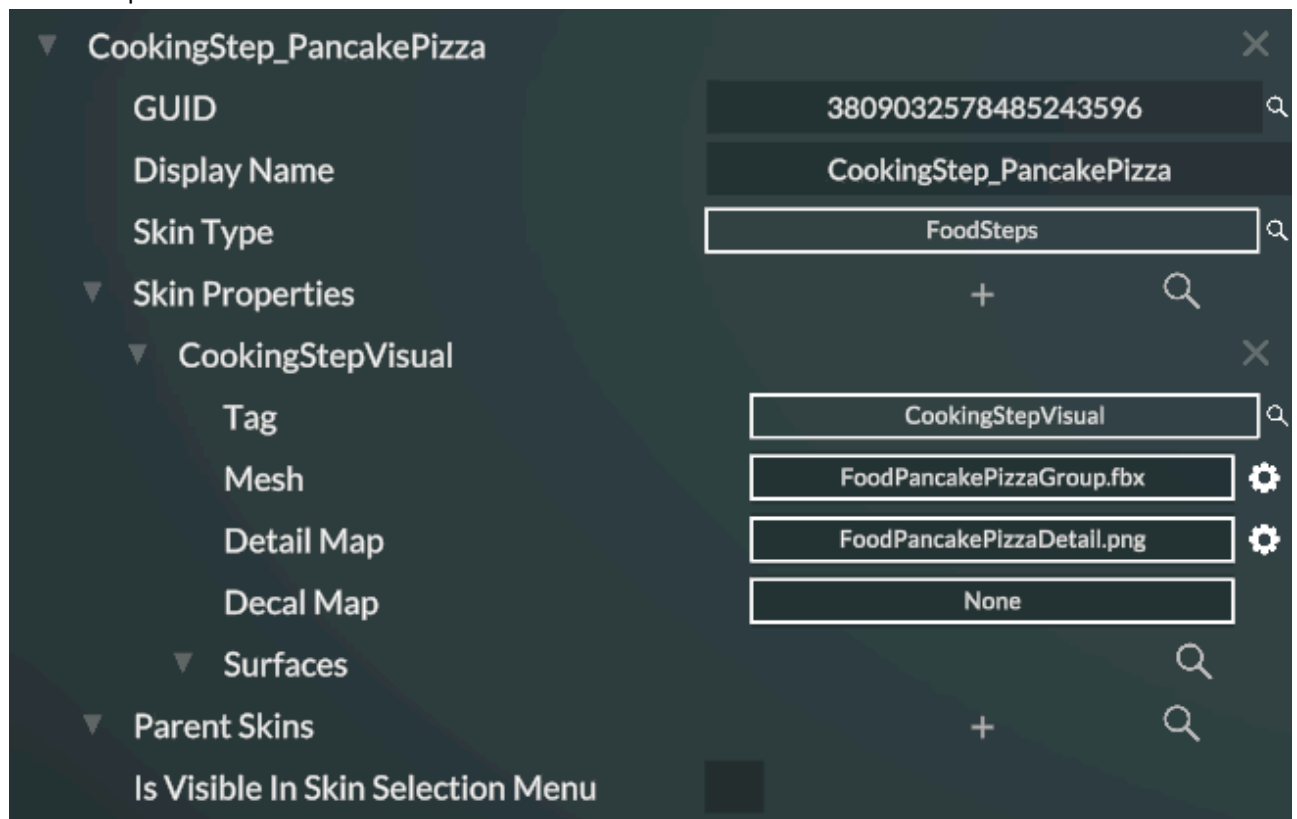


Modded CookingStep_MyFood setup

If you have group and single servings as options for cooking, ensure you created `CookingStep_MyFood_Individual` and do the following for both.

1. Set Skin Type to FoodSteps.
 2. You only need to add `CookingStepVisual` to the Skin Properties here.
- Mesh: Your finished meal.

- Detail Map: Your finished meal.



Step 3: Testing your food and recipe in-game

_(I highly suggest creating a new game using the Simple Empty Terrain)

1. *If you have set your recipe for all Cooking Initial Skins Packs or Extra Initial Skins Packs, you can skip this step if clicking Cook on the fridge has your recipe displayed already.* Press Ctrl+Shift+C to open the Command/Cheat Window. Type **LEARNALLSKINS recipes** into the text box. This will immediately unlock all recipes, and if your food shows up in this list it is working properly, and will be unlocked through usual gameplay that unlocks vanilla recipes, such as researching recipes on the computer. _(If your thumbnail is not showing up, ensure you have set it during the Skin Properties stage of this guide.)

How your meal will show in the menu. Note that it is categorised by skill requirement



2. Be sure to check each aspect of the meal that we set up, such as recipe steps/stages, visual changes from full -> half, and eating animation + the in hand appearance. **At this stage the mesh will show up with a flat solid texture. If you were able to apply the detail map to the FBX mesh directly outside of the game, it might show with the correct texture, so try it if you want. If I find this works, I will update the guide with confirmation.** *The pizza mesh has a white flat texture, so it appears white*



The single half-eaten mesh has a different flat texture, so shows up differently



3. If the meal is working properly, you will see it filling or displaying an icon on the hunger bar. It won't be selectable if it wasn't, but if you want to confirm look for the green face icon next to the bar. It will show up if the Para is fill, and indicates directly that the need is being replenished correctly. *Hunger*

restoration confirmation



Thanks for reading!

I'm sorry if this ending is a bit abrupt. I lost much progress on this guide after an issue with a recent Windows 11 update reverted a lot of progress. Thank you for reading, and I look forward to seeing what everyone creates! 😊